

AI ETHICS LEARNING TOOLKIT

Does AI Spread Mis/Disinfo?

Exploring Deep Fakes and Mis/Disinformation

“The popular emergence of generative AI has deepened uncertainty in an already-skeptical information environment, leading people to suspect that anything could be the product of synthetic media.”

– Charlie Warzel, technology journalist at *The Atlantic*

From Taylor Swift deepfakes to synthetic AI robocalls from politicians, AI tools have the potential to turn any message into a viral disinformation campaign. Disinformation refers to “false, inaccurate, or misleading information designed, presented and promoted to intentionally cause public harm or for profit.” Misinformation is similar in nature, but the sharers of misinformation may have done so accidentally and without intent to harm. AI models aren’t human – they don’t possess intent to harm, whether deliberately or inadvertently. So, what’s the concern? Some argue that the ready availability and low cost of AI tools could facilitate the spread of higher quality mis/disinformation by bad (human) actors. Others

argue the danger of this is overblown and there is insufficient evidence-based research to support the hype. It may be some time before we fully understand the impact of AI-generated mis/disinformation, students should be aware of the potential ways in which AI could be used to manipulate text, images, video, and information sources. They should remain critical consumers and sharers of information they come across.

Learning Activities

Conversation Starters A Few Questions to Get the Discussion Going

- Have you ever come across a deepfake, or mis/disinformation online? How could you tell?
- What are some scenarios you can imagine where mis/disinformation could cause real-world harm?
- Who do you think is most susceptible to being manipulated by mis/disinformation? Why do you think they are more vulnerable to being swayed by it?

Active Learning with AI Fun Ways to Explore AI's Strengths and Limitations

- Students can create fake content with AI for a faux disinformation campaign. Share the prompt, AI outputs, and have the class react.

- Students can discuss a case study from the [Disinformation Studies syllabus](#). Case Studies include: Japanese incarceration, media and the AIDs crisis, the myth of the “Welfare Queen”, and more.
- Instructor can choose some examples from [#deepfake-tagged](#) articles in Snopes.com for students to discuss. Ask students to reflect on the ways the Snopes authors fact-checked the claim.

Disciplinary Extensions Ideas for Exploring AI’s Impact in Specific Fields

- **Psychology:** Research has found that when disinformation is more targeted and personalized, it is more persuasive. What are some of the psychological (phenomena) at play in the creation and consumption of disinformation?
- **History:** Students could look at the historical roots of disinformation and make connections to modern day AI narratives.
- **Arts & Humanities:** What is the role of visual/media arts in disinformation/propaganda campaigns?
- **Computer Science/Engineering:** What are some of the most promising detection technologies that could help identify fake content?

Resources

- Elliott, V. (2024, Sept. 2nd). [AI-Fakes Detection Is Failing Voters in the Global South](#). *Wired*. [Magazine article]  
- Mehrotra, D. (2024, June 19th). [Perplexity Is a Bullshit Machine](#). *Wired*. [Magazine article]  
- Hsu, T., & Thompson, S. A. (2024, July 11). [Even Disinformation Experts Don't Know How to Stop It](#). *The New York Times*.  

- UNC CITAP. (2021). [Does Not Compute](#). This podcast predates the GAI explosion but includes numerous, excellent episodes on disinformation. [Podcast] 🎧

Scholarly

- Kuo, R., & Marwick, A. (2021). [Critical disinformation studies: History, power, and politics](#). *Harvard Kennedy School Misinformation Review*. [Article] 📄
- Sison, A. J. G., Daza, M. T., Gozalo-Brizuela, R., & Garrido-Merchán, E. C. (2023). [ChatGPT: More than a Weapon of Mass Deception, Ethical challenges and responses from the Human-Centered Artificial Intelligence \(HCAI\) perspective](#). *arXiv*. [Preprint] 📄
- Simon, F. M., Altay, S., & Mercier, H. (2023). [Misinformation reloaded? Fears about the impact of generative AI on misinformation are overblown](#). *Harvard Kennedy School Misinformation Review*. [Article] 📄
- Matz, S. C., et al. (2024). [The potential of generative AI for personalized persuasion at scale](#). *Scientific Reports*, 14(1), 4692. [Article] 📄 🗂️

Recommendations

- Related topics → Does AI harm critical thinking? Is AI biased?
- UNC's [Critical Disinformation Studies: a Syllabus](#) project
- [AI Pedagogy Project \(Harvard\) Assignments](#) → Filter by theme (e.g. misinformation) and/or subject (e.g. journalism)
- [Mis/disinformation-related Articles](#) from the AI Ethics & Policy News Aggregator sourced by [Casey Fiesler](#). Note: This would be an excellent place to identify recent news stories you could share with students, or incorporate into a case study.

-
1. Directorate-General for Communications Networks, Content and Technology (European Commission). (2018). *A multi-dimensional approach to disinformation: Report of the independent High level Group on fake news and online disinformation*. Publications Office of the European Union. <https://data.europa.eu/doi/10.2759/739290>
 2. Matz, S. C., Teeny, J. D., Vaid, S. S., Peters, H., Harari, G. M., & Cerf, M. (2024). The potential of generative AI for personalized persuasion at scale. *Scientific Reports*, 14(1), 4692. <https://doi.org/10.1038/s41598-024-53755->
 3. Simon, F. M., Altay, S., & Mercier, H. (2023). Misinformation reloaded? Fears about the impact of generative AI on misinformation are overblown. *Harvard Kennedy School Misinformation Review*. <https://doi.org/10.37016/mr-2020-127>

PHYSICAL LOCATION

The Erwin Square Mill Building
2024 West Main Street
Durham, NC 27705

MAILING ADDRESS

Box 90700
Durham, NC 27708

CONTACT US

Phone: (919) 660-5806
Email:
learninginnovation@duke.edu

CONNECT WITH US



BROWSE

- What We Do
- About
- Blog
- Contact Us
- Events
- Directions
- Resources
- Newsletter Signup